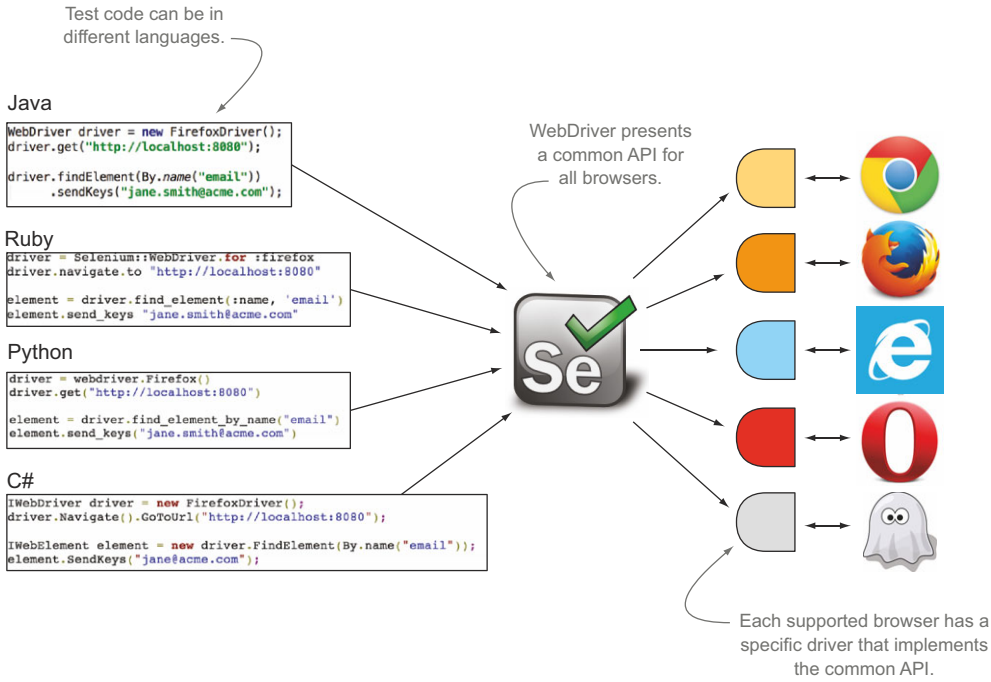


Figure 8.4 Overview of the WebDriver architecture

You can also run web tests in *headless* mode, using a special JavaScript-based browser called PhantomJS.

WebDriver tests can be written in a number of languages, including Java, Groovy, Ruby, C#, and Python. The WebDriver API varies little from one language to another, so you can generally use the language you're most comfortable with, or the one that provides the most value for you in terms of ease of writing, maintainability, and living documentation.

The WebDriver API is powerful and flexible, but there are several open source libraries for different platforms that can help you build on WebDriver to write web tests more efficiently and more expressively, including Thucydides, Watir, WatiN, and Geb. We'll look at some of these libraries in action in section 8.3.2. For most of this chapter, you'll use the WebDriver API with Java.

8.2.1 Getting started with WebDriver in Java

Let's start with a very simple example of web browser automation with WebDriver. You'll illustrate WebDriver's features using a simple version of the Flying High Frequent Flyer website that we've discussed in previous chapters.

If you want to follow along, you can download both the website and the sample code from either the GitHub repository (https://github.com/bdd-in-action/chapter-8) or from the Manning website. The sample code repository contains two directories: